

Assignment 3: Reflections and Lessons from the Internship

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Assignment 3: Final Reflection

Throughout the 2024-2025 school year, I worked as the Marketing and Communications Intern at the San Jose Office of Economic Development and Cultural Affairs. In this role I assisted the Public Information Manager, Carlos Velazquez, from October 2024 - June 2025 for 10 hours per week. Throughout my first few days in the office, I began outreach for the next blog post announcing the recipients of the Creative Economy Fund Grant, created posts and infographics for Instagram, and compiled a list of free workshops for the newsletter to small businesses from OEDCA partners. At first, it was daunting to be emailing prominent nonprofit companies, creating captions and images for the @SJeconomy Instagram page, and writing blog posts for the city's website. However, with constant support and feedback from my advisor, Carlos Velasquez, my confidence began to grow. I was also fortunate enough to sit in on a Team San Jose meeting with San Jose Theatres, where we took a tour of the San Jose Civic Center and Montgomery Theatre after discussing recent revenues for San Jose Theatres.

One thing that surprises me about this organization is how much everyone in the office genuinely loves their job. There's a shared passion for making real change and promoting San Jose's prosperity, which is infectious. It's incredibly motivating to be surrounded by people who are both committed to their work and deeply care about the community they serve. The sense of camaraderie is clear as coworkers share jokes and lunch invitations throughout the day in the

office. My advisor made it a priority for me to be formally introduced to everyone I interact with, whether virtually or in person, which made me feel at home from the beginning. Each introduction started with a warm smile and a firm handshake, and by prioritizing face-to-face connections, my advisor fostered a supportive and interconnected environment for me and the entire office. This has helped me ease into my role, knowing there are countless people who know me by name and are more than willing to help me through my journey.

I think the most impactful experience from being in the Office of Economic Development and Cultural Affairs, was being able to immerse myself in a healthy, driven, and interconnected company culture. The OEDCA's team is filled with the most passionate employees I have ever met, all of them extremely well-rounded and multi-faceted. Most employees will expand their responsibilities past their job description, because they identify a gap in their work that they want to fill. My advisor, Carlos Velazquez, wears many hats as the Public Information Manager at the City of San Jose. Carlos is the only staff member at the OEDCA that is responsible for their marketing which includes, but is not limited to, social media, SJ economy website, monthly newsletters, and external outreach. We work to raise awareness, fostering trust throughout the city, and catering to the needs of the stakeholders. Being responsible for the OEDCA's marketing requires ample adaptability and strategic problem solving skills. I have learned many lessons from this position that I can apply to other roles that I may be interviewing or working for. I have gained skills like data analysis, presentations, casual networking, external and internal communication/outreach, and how to behave in a professional environment. When working for the City of San Jose, the stakeholders are more than just "customers", they are the residents, businesses, city leaders, and students of San Jose. Managing such a diverse set of stakeholders requires everyday adaptability, negotiation skills, and resilience.

In alignment with the EMPAC Model, I learned a lot about how to appeal to consumers, how to make small business resources accessible and convenient, what it means to be a small business owner in the San Jose environment and economy, and who in the City of San Jose is our target market for these resources.

By far the most rewarding experience in my internship has been working directly with small businesses. I had the opportunity to interview a few small business owners in San Jose for various Heritage Month Spotlights, and in doing so I got to hear first hand the stories behind their businesses. Every person that I interviewed had so much love and passion for their community, and worked to integrate their own culture into their business so that they can share it with their community. It was inspiring to hear the diverse experiences each person held close to their heart, and how they integrate their heritage into their business and greater San Jose community. The most impactful experiences during my time at the OEDCA have been through meeting new people, hearing their stories, and developing relationships throughout San Jose.